

Informal gardens

Country gardens, cottage gardens, wildlife plots, and prairie-style plantings are all informal designs. Unlike formal schemes, they allow a greater degree of flexibility in the design and planting plans.

Cottage gardens

Cottage gardens are traditionally simple in layout, often with a central path leading to the main door and planting beds filled with flowers, herbs, and vegetables on either side. If the garden is large enough, it may also include more naturalistic areas, such as orchards, meadows, and informal wildlife ponds.

The edges of flower beds are softened by a rich profusion of planting, with the flowers encouraged to fall over the path and self-seed at random. Typical cottage garden plants include hellebores, lungworts (*Pulmonaria*), grape hyacinths (*Muscari*), aquilegias, and species daffodils and tulips in spring, with hardy geraniums, lilies, lupins, poppies, campanulas, delphiniums, hollyhocks (*Alcea rosea*) and peonies in summer. Plants are often chosen for their range of flower forms, textures, and colors. Edible crops, such as herbs, vegetables, and fruit trees and bushes, are mixed with the ornamental plants, adding to the atmosphere of abundance and informality.

Natural stone, brick, cobbles, and slate are the best materials for hard landscaping, while simple post-and-rail or picket fences are ideal for boundaries and divisions.

Country gardens

Country gardens also have a relaxed style, with sweeping expanses of lawn and curved, flower-filled mixed beds and borders. Hedges are often used to divide the garden into a series of enclosed spaces with different planting designs and atmospheres in each.

Prairie and wildlife gardens

Prairie planting, championed by many contemporary designers, echoes the tightly woven density of cottage-garden planting by combining broad sweeps of ornamental grasses and sturdy perennials. Grasses such as stipas and calamagrostis are threaded through perennials, such as rudbeckias, echinaceas, symphyotrichums, and heleniums. Prairie schemes suit large, open sites in full sun, where the bold swaths of planting produce the best effects.

Wildlife gardens are designed to provide habitats for birds, insects, and mammals. Domestic gardens can also be wildlife gardens, with naturalistic planting schemes comprising of nectar-rich flowers, and trees

for nesting and shelter. An informal pond is usually a feature, to provide homes for amphibians, reptiles, and insects.

Gardeners with more space may opt for a wildflower meadow. These require a sunny site and infertile soil for the rich profusion of native wildflowers and grasses to thrive.

RIGHT Prairie-style plantings

Prairie-style gardens combine the soft, feathery effects of grasses with the muted hues of perennials. Planted in informal drifts, this late summer scheme includes eupatorium, echinacea, and sedum.

BELOW Cottage-garden informality and abundance

The profuse pink flowers of a climbing rose clambering over an arbor echo the equally abundant planting of cottage-garden perennials in the beds below.

